



Moral conflict and dynamic equilibrium: Public relations as strategic conflict management

Jae-Hwa Shin

School of Media and Communication University of Southern Mississippi, USA

ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Contingency theory
Strategic conflict management
Public relations
Moral conflict
Dynamic equilibrium
Advocacy
Accommodation
Continuum

ABSTRACT

In the literature review and proposed theoretical models, the author argues that we often engage in advocacy in public relations on behalf of causes we hold dear, much like a strong defender on a soccer field becomes physical in defending the goal without violating explicit rules or our sense of what is right and appropriate in a competitive world. The author presents this image of an athlete contending in fair competition as a metaphor for a rejection of canonized thinking about accommodation in public relations in favor of public relations as strategic conflict management. This research is offered to continue the discussion in the field of public relations from the contingency theory of strategic conflict management and consider the ethical challenges faced by public relations practitioners in an ongoing cycle of conflict. This article is included in the special issue on the contingency theory of strategic conflict management.

1. Overview

“Public relations” is an oxymoron. This semantic problem has contributed to the conflicting nature, goals, values, roles, and functions of public relations. The ethical consideration of public interest in organization-public relationships has been one of the challenging issues confronting public relations since the bottom line for public relations must be what is in the best interest of the organization that public relations practitioners serve and impose on them the inherent obligation. It often brings about conflict in public relations practice insofar as the ethical consideration of public interest is ultimately in the best interest of the organization. It is accompanied by professional ethical guidelines and personal values. To best conceptualize such conflicting aspects, public relations can be identified as a dynamic process of negotiation on a moving continuum as suggested by the contingency theory of strategic conflict management.

Contingency theory arose in the 1990s in response to the emphasis on achieving the two-way symmetrical model, which “generally [is] conducted more ethically than other models” (Grunig, Grunig, & Dozier, 2006, p. 40). Rather than concentrating on discovering principles, contingency theory emphasizes that context and situation – a nexus of factors – affect the strategic and ethical decisions of public relations professionals. Moreover, as the situation unfolds, stances and positions are likely to change to accommodate and ethically respond to publics in dynamic situations (Cameron, Wilcox, Reber & Shin, 2008; Wilcox, Reber, Shin, & Cameron, 2023).

Public relations may be characterized as a dynamic process itself. Power balancing can be sought only under the premise that both an

organization and its public have autonomous advocacy for their positions and stakes. At a certain point, an organization-public relationship can be nearly symmetrical, but never remains static in such a power-balancing process. This study seeks to identify the conflicting aspect of “ethics” and “effects” and conceptualize the dynamic morality of public relations for its purpose of advocacy.

How much morality or advocacy is enough in a public relations process? Morality is a social system of rules, conventions, ideals, and sanctions, with the function of maintaining harmony and cooperation (Buchanan, 1965). Advocacy, on the other hand, is identified as “the act of publicly representing an individual, organization, or idea with the object of persuading targeted audiences to look favorably on – or accept the point of view of – the individual, the organization, or the idea” (Edgett, 2002, p. 1). As a core concept of the public relations discipline, organizational advocacy has been seen in conflict with its sense of morality (Barney & Black, 1994; Bivins, 1987; McBride, 1989; Nelson, 1994; Sallot, 1993).

The extent to which an organization acts in the larger public interest depends on its degree of advocacy. The more advocacy an organization has, the smaller the margins for concern with the larger public interest are unless driven by some sense that it will do the greatest good for the greatest number—a circumstance that does not always occur and may even be rare. Public relations practitioners may act symmetrically in one situation and asymmetrically in another situation when dealing with the same public (Cameron, 1997; Cancel, Cameron, Sallot & Mitrook, 1997).

Public relations practitioners may also try to act symmetrically involving one public and thus may behave asymmetrically involving another public. Thus, they often adopt utilitarian ethics, measuring the

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.pubrev.2023.102321>

Received 18 December 2020; Received in revised form 1 December 2022; Accepted 21 March 2023

Available online 8 April 2023

0363-8111/© 2023 Elsevier Inc. All rights reserved.

ethical aspect of decisions based on the outcome. In most public relations contexts, successful outcomes are taken to be at least mutually satisfactory solutions and at best moderating self-interest and maximizing the public good. A dynamic equilibrium may be the essence of the morality and power of public relations and its strategic move on a continuum.

2. The logic of dynamic morality

This study seeks to expand this ethical approach by considering the constraints of two-way symmetrical practice, accepting morally appropriate causes to behave one-way asymmetrically involving publics, and embracing its dynamic nature. The moral conflict inherent in the relationship between an organization and its public, or two parties working for conflicting interests, can be strategically managed on a moving continuum as suggested by the contingency theory of strategic conflict management (Cameron et al. 2008). This is a theoretical review with proposed models conceptualizing a moving continuum of dynamic morality as the explication of the contingency theory of strategic conflict management.

First, there are often moral conflicts or a set of “moral dilemmas” associated with individual, organizational, and societal ethics whereby different options are available that may test the deontological imperative or universal moral duty to do no harm to an individual or group or to act for the good of society (Mata, 2019, p. 1061). Moral conflicts arise in everyday situations as well as surrounding issues that are often highly contested based on nonnegotiable positions such as ingrained religious beliefs. It is often difficult to define which level of ethical standards should be most applicable, or what to do when the positions of opponents are intractable (Tatalovich, 2017). Understanding how moral conflicts operate in the real world is complicated by a “paucity of validated everyday moral decision-making paradigms” that would allow researchers to measure and compare the behaviors of individuals and groups in a situation that presents moral dilemmas (Singer, Kruszpointner, Sommer, Wüst & Kudielka, 2019, p. 2). Moral conflicts come at financial and reputational costs to organizations, and it is thus in their interest to reduce the occurrence (Nelson, 2008). Moral conflicts require a balance between self-interest and the desire to act out of altruism for the good of the community (Singer et al., 2019).

Sullivan (1989) defined the various value systems operating in public relations, locating the center of public relations ethics at the point where mutual and individual values meet and further suggested that the system is morally impartial. Empirical research on public relations ethics indicates that practitioners tend to believe that the ethics of their dominant coalition is higher than their own (Pratt, 1991). Pratt (1993) also argued that ethics in public relations is more a consequence of practitioners’ routine adherence to circumstances. On the other hand, “the reality is that people form convictions, which to them are moral absolutes. This deontological approach is often more than simply bowing to management or being coopted by an organization” (p. 32). The collision of these different world views and paradigms leads to inevitable conflicts as organizations and individuals engage in ethical decision-making processes. To realistically approach public relations ethics, public relations professionals should realize moral conflicts and discover the contexts where social worlds collide (Pearce & Littlejohn, 1997).

Second, universal ethics in public relations are identified with the professional self-worth of practitioners who are bound to it. Wright (1993) suggested that most public relations practitioners are ethical not because they believe that they should, but because they want to be. This represents the “moral autonomy” of individual public relations practitioners and excludes the moral hypocrisy of the “duty for duty’s sake” implied by the deontological approach (Bradley, 1962, pp. 142–143). There are no moral absolutes without a basis of individual autonomy (Rand, 1982). In turn, any individual public relations practitioner behaves in their ethical value system, often accompanied by their own organizational and social values (Cameron, 1997).

Third, public relations is in the domain of an organization’s management. Many scholars agree that public relations is a management function that is linked to the external environment (Broom & Dozier, 1994; Ferguson, 1984; Ledingham & Bruning, 2000; Toth & Trujillo, 1987). Cameron (1997) argued, “crucial advocacy in public relations is often directed at one’s own organization” (p. 54). In other words, the important work of public relations is as much introspective as it is focused on external stakeholders and outside relationships. The question is what extent of moral obligations is enough for public relations and organizational effectiveness. If there is no bottom line for moral obligation, is there no ceiling for organizational effectiveness?

Fourth, public relations has institutional controls such as legal constraints, government regulations, activist claims, and cultural norms (Cameron, 1997). All these factors conspire to create conflicts between the loyalties faced by public relations practitioners such as self, organization, profession, and society in pursuit of the common good (Wright, 1993). However, identifying the common good is not always feasible unless it represents the good of a dominant coalition (Nomos, 1967).

Fifth, public relations realistically cannot satisfy equally multiple diametric publics at the same time (Cameron, 1997). Ethical decision-making involves the clarification of values, the application of appropriate principles, and the choice of priorities between conflicting responsibilities to different publics (Baker, 1999). All the conflicting parties, and their causes or interests, tend to impose ethical constraints on their own choice of behavior; that is, their situational responses to the choice options that may confront them subsequently. Furthermore, ethical decision-making is not monologic in the sense that each of the entities involved in interactions benefits from the presence of ethical considerations of others with whom each party expects to interact in a large and complex nexus (Buchanan, 1965). Although public relations practitioners strive to achieve perfect symmetry and unreserved mutual satisfaction of all internal and external stakeholders, it does not mean that they ever reach the ideal.

Sixth, human beings and their actions in a coalition, i.e. an organization or a public, are not always reasonable (Cameron, 1997). The contingency theory of public relations assumes irrational or emotional human beings. A normative approach seeks to regulate everything rationally. If human beings always acted reasonably, it would be unnecessary to exhort them to be guided by rationale. The cognitive limits of human capacities, especially in a variety of situations, may make it rational to adopt relatively rigid rules (Heiner, 1985). In the dynamics of morality, it is suggested that public relations practitioners exercise rationality and “always act intelligently ... in their own rightly understood interest” (Mises, 2005, p. xxi). The essence of dynamic morality in public relations wants to concede a great latitude of human affairs and reason in the sphere of moral autonomy, possibly without dispute in all other spheres of ethical premises.

3. Moral conflict and dynamic equilibrium in organization-public relationships

3.1. Proposed model I

The dynamic equilibrium on a continuum is a logical explication of the relationship between an organization and the public (Cameron, Cropp, & Reber, 2001). Shin (2003) developed the idea of mixed views as hybrid points of advocacy and accommodation into the contingency theory of strategic conflict management. To explicate the fluid and complex nature of public relations practice affected by many contingent variables, the organization-public relationships which are unrelentingly asymmetrical move along dynamic equilibrium (Fig. 1). Beyond a simplistic way of defining public relations as the management function which facilitate mutually beneficial relationships between an organization and its public, what can be the nature, goals, needs, values, process, rules, roles, functions, or consequent effects of the relationship between an organization and its public?

As noted earlier, “public relations” is an oxymoron. The functions or roles of public relations practitioners have something to do with the paradoxical definition of public relations work (Alan, 1994). Baskin and Arnoff (1992) asserted that “public relations as a profession attempts to represent the public as well as the organization/business decision making” (p. 87).

It is fair to say that the conflict between “public” and “relations” is always situated in public relations because each involves inherently different and sometimes disputing goals, roles, needs, processes, and desired outcomes.

Conflict is often defined as any situation in which there is a divergence of interests or values, beyond involvement or knowledge (Fisher, 1997; Hocker & Wilmot, 1991; Rubin, Pruitt, & Kim, 1994; Tatalovich, 2017; Tillet, 1990). For example, Plowman et al. (1995) examined discrepancies in self-interests and values that underlie conflict between Walgreens and customers. Cameron et al. (2008) described public relations as an ongoing cycle of strategic conflict management, linking public relations to conflict management. The definition of conflict holds particular promise for the understanding of moral conflict between “public” and “relations.”

The concept of public is well defined by Dewey (1927) as a group of people who confront a similar problem, acknowledge that the problem exists, and organize to address the problem. Blumer (1966) similarly characterized a public as “a group of people who are confronted by an issue, divided in their idea about how to meet the issue, and engaged in discussion about the issue” (pp. 186–187).

Hallahan (2000) classified publics into five categories in terms of knowledge and involvement: 1) inactive publics are conceptualized as groups composed of individuals who possess a comparatively low level of knowledge and involvement in an organization and its operations; 2) aroused publics share a comparatively low level of knowledge about an organization, but their level of involvement is mobilized in response to a potential problem or issue; 3) aware publics are knowledgeable about an organization and its activities and might be able to articulate the origins, processes, and consequences of potential issues; 4) active publics are composed of people who share both high levels of knowledge about, and involvement in, an organization or an issue; and 5) non-publics are the default component composed of individuals who have no knowledge

and no involvement with an organization. A certain level of knowledge and involvement of a public can be criteria to identify the public’s status in a given situation. Once individuals gain any level of knowledge or involvement, they become inactive public status. As their knowledge or involvement is getting increased around a topic, they become an active public, which plays a pivotal role in ordering an issue and helping to determine the fate of an organization.

As Flynn (2006) described, maintaining a “delicate balance” between the interests of stakeholders and those of an organization is the goal of public relations, which is complicated by the fact that “the public spaces in which we compete and communicate have never been more complex and unpredictable” (p. 193). Equally, the pressure to forge mutually beneficial relationships is complicated by the ready accessibility and proliferation of information (Tapscott & Ticoll, 2003). Collective groups of the public have the ability to form and define themselves to disassociate from institutional identity. An organization cannot simply impose its interpretation of the world because “the public is the locus of the signification process,” and the meaning “is not an attribute of the message or in the domain of the message designer” (Vasquez, 1994, p. 62). Olasky (1984) called attention to the public’s role which is inherently part of the process of public relations. Moffitt (1992) addressed that “the ‘problematizing’ of unquestioned, absolute allegiance to an organization supports recognition of the publics we communicate to, in turn, encouraging ethical responsibility to the person we communicate to and the environment we all inhabit” (p. 17).

According to Bailey (1981), public interest “is the central concept of a civilized policy, and its genius lies not in its clarity but in its perverse and persistent moral intrusion upon the internal and external discourse of rules and rules alike” (p. 141). The notion of public interest includes both negative and positive aspects. Negatively, public interest “consists in the establishment and maintenance of order... (one) can rely on the other not to interfere; each is guaranteed a wide enough scope for private action and the development of his own personality” (Fagothey, 1976, p. 248). Positively, public interest “consists in giving to others and receiving from them the powers and resources that as individuals one would possess” (Fagothey, 1976, p. 248). Offering the value of public relations in society, Martinson (1995) argued that ethical public relations practitioners should pay attention to public interest. He

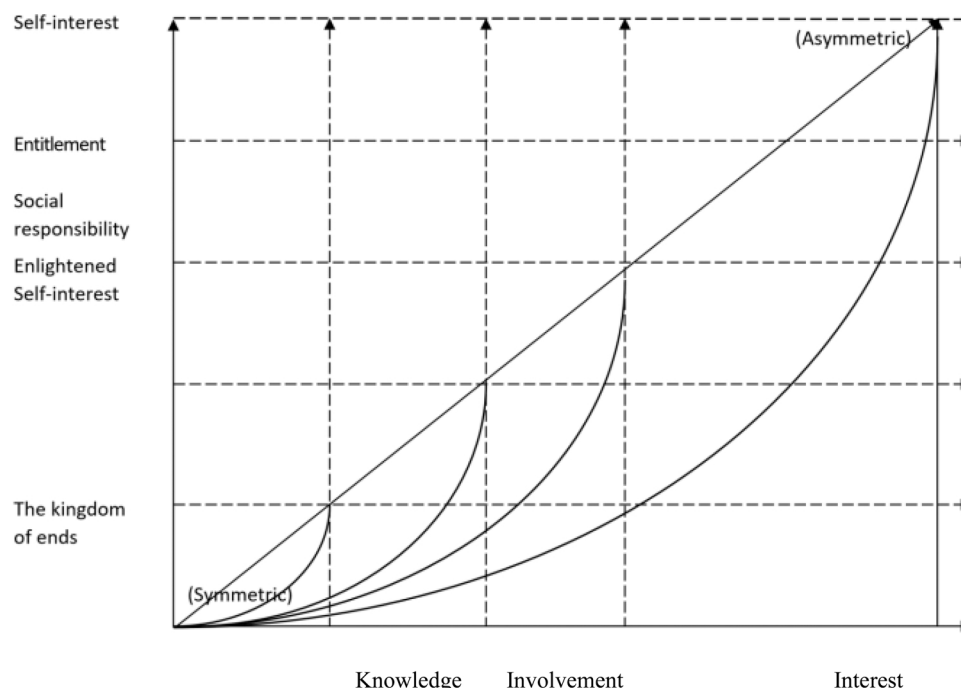


Fig. 1. Moral Conflict and Dynamic Equilibrium in Organization-Public Relationships.

maintained that public interest is the core definition of what public relations is. [Jaksa and Pritchard \(1994\)](#) suggested that public relations practitioners must determine whether their actions are in the public interest or not. Is it possible to prevent particular persons or groups from making unfair exceptions of themselves or to satisfy all persons or groups around an issue or a problem? To what extent is a particular decision of a public relations practitioner rationally justified or possibly accepted in the larger public interest?

Scholars raised questions about the symmetrical relationship between an organization and its public in the conflicting concept of public relations. [Hellweg \(1989\)](#) suggested that the notions of one-way asymmetrical relationships to two-way symmetrical relationships depend heavily on one's perspective and change on a continuum. [Murphy \(1991\)](#) proposed the concept of mixed motives ranging from conflict to cooperation in public relations. She pointed out that the symmetrical model is similar to a zero-sum game or pure cooperation, which is seldom found in the real world of public relations. She argued that it is more practical for an organization and its public to negotiate in the continuum range of the bipolar points that represent each side's interests. [Leichty \(1997\)](#) addressed the limits of collaboration, that is, "collaborative public relations is unfeasible in some situations," and "certain types of conflicts virtually require asymmetric or win-lose public relations efforts" (p. 47).

[Barney and Black \(1994\)](#) discussed the conflict between "public," which represents ethical consideration of public interest, and "relationship," which corresponds to the consequent effects of the organization-public relationship. They found the conflict in two distinct heritages between which "public relations practitioners are torn: the objectivity ethic of the journalist, and the persuasion ethic of the advocate" (p. 69). They argued that the persuasion ethic is justifiable and worthy in a participatory democracy. It is assumed that there are acting and counteracting messages. According to [Barney and Black \(1994\)](#), "such a role justifies the distribution of 'selective truth,' relieving a public relations person from the obligation to tell 'objective truth,' and allows for ethical persuasion (p. 233).

The conflict between ethical consideration of public interest and organizational effectiveness has long been discussed as one of the most central issues ([Pratt, 1994](#); [Stauber & Rampton, 1995](#)). According to [Alkhafaji \(1989\)](#), "there is obviously an ambiguity between what is accepted behavior in business and what is accepted behavior in the broader society" (p. 203). Most public relations practitioners want good reasons or moral justification to support their actions and commitments. However, seldom does a single ethical path work in daily practice. Paths merge and diverge organically. It is more realistic for public relations practitioners to adopt a deontic ethic balanced with consequentialism. Deontological responses to moral dilemmas often appear to be more immediate and intuitive than consequential ones ([Mata, 2019](#)).

However, duty for duty's sake is challenging for public relations practitioners in daily practice. [Kant \(1964\)](#) asserted, "the obligation of the good conscience is to do its duty for the sake of duty" (p. 62). [Kant \(1965\)](#) also claimed that all actions should be "governed by the categorical imperative duties", which are universal and unconditional moral obligations. Such a deontological ethical system produces irresolvable conflicts when a public relations practitioner perceives a true moral dilemma among duties.

There are many duties, which may be a conflict of obligations. If an act is serving the organization, it may be right for the organization, but if it is a case of generating social benefit, it may be also right for society. For instance, if a public relations practitioner is acting on behalf of the organization against personal ethical responsibility, she/he may not be acting morally. On the other hand, for a public relations practitioner to hold professional ethics, it is not only the responsibility to the public but also the adherence to a Kantian maxim. It seems plausible to suggest that moral choice among conflicting norms may be treated as "relative absolute" absolutes ([Buchanan, 1965](#)).

Thus, many public relations practitioners accept the practical ethics

inherent in their jobs while maintaining a guiding principle that reflects Ross's *prima facie* duties thesis. In citing [Ross \(1930\)](#), [Vergobbi \(1995\)](#) indicated how "competing duties make it incumbent upon the agent to decide which duty carries the greatest moral weight for a given circumstance. The situationists' decisions are based on what would cause the least harm or most good" (p. 241), depending on an actual situation. According to [Rawls \(1971\)](#), a social contract provides a moral basis to reconcile the conflicting claims in a free enterprise system for a democratic society. Public relations practitioners probably choose a course of action on a continuum of ethical dilemma in a given situation that balances the public interest, the employer, the professional organization's code of ethics, and their personal values ([Wilcox, Cameron, Reber, & Shin, 2013](#)).

It is also important to acknowledge that the extent of minimum harm or maximum benefit is derived from a moral calculus based on absolute values held by each side ([Guy, 1990](#), p. 39). With this basic assumption, [Guy \(1990\)](#) provided a summary statement on how to cope with moral conflict in a situation; "ethical decision making is the process of identifying a problem, generating alternatives, and choosing among them so that the alternatives selected maximize the most important ethical values while also achieving the intended goal" (p. 40).

As an approach to moral conflict between "public" and "relations" in a perspective of persuasive advocacy with moral justification, [Baker \(1999\)](#) introduced a framework consisting of five baselines of ethical justification. The models are identified as self-interest, entitlement, enlightened self-interest, social responsibility, and kingdom of ends. These can offer a conceptual framework by which to examine ethical decision-making in public relations theory and practice.

The self-interest model is based on the ideas of [Nelson \(1994\)](#) and [Smith \(1995\)](#). [Nelson \(1994\)](#) observed that the public relations profession lacks a "single common framework for deciding what is ethical and what is not" (p. 225), and what "would do well to re-evaluate the bases for our ethics" (p. 229). [Smith \(1995\)](#) also wrote about market strategies:

If it was legal to sell a product that might be harmful, but might not live up to the seller's promises, then marketing the products was acceptable because the decision to buy was the consumer's. The consumer was expected to employ the maxim, 'buyer beware' (p. 85).

The entitlement model stems from the self-interest model but extends to the assertion of legal rights. The presumption is that "everybody is entitled to present a point of view, and is entitled to professional assistance" ([Seitel, 1995](#), p. 11). Persuasive communications are "forms of professional behavior protected to an extent by the First Amendment, and the position that 'if it's legal, it's ethical'" ([Black, 1992](#), p. 242). Thus, persuasive advocates have a duty to "vigorously defend the client in public arenas without concern for balancing messages" ([Barney & Black, 1994](#), p. 240). The model suggests that public relations practitioners are equivalent to lawyers in the sense that they advocate the interests of their clients in an adversarial society: "All organizations, individuals, and clients have a right to advocacy. No matter who they are or what they wish to promote within the law" ([Newsom, Turk, & Kruckeberg, 1996](#), p. 199).

The enlightened self-interest model posits that good deeds lead to financial success, and thus engaging in ethical behavior is profitable for businesses:

Why, some might ask, would insurers want to raise performance standards to such heights, especially in light of persistent pressures to manage costs? The ironic conclusion is that raising standards enables companies to focus their resources where they really belong, on finding and keeping satisfied customers. In other words, ethical sales practices are good for business ([Finnell & Fleming, 1997](#), p. 23).

Enlightened self-interest, along with principled negotiation strategies, is also explained in conflict management and negotiation literature (e.g.,

Fisher & Ury, 1986).

The social responsibility model draws on the fields of journalism, business, and communitarianism:

Social responsibility in journalism appeals to responsibility to community over self-interest, profit or careerism; to social ethics over rampant libertarian individual interest. The essence of social ethics is to recognize that humans are accountable to each other, interdependent and not isolated selves (Christians, Fackler, & Rotzoll, 1995, p. 330).

The kingdom of ends model is based on Kant's categorical imperative:

[A]ct only on that maxim through which you can at the same time will be that it should become a universal law... always act according to a maxim which a rational being, living in a community of rational beings, will autonomously for the benefit of every member in the community (Kant, 1965, p. 56).

This categorical imperative assumes that "since everyone has duties to

himself and to others, it is the duty of everyone to harmonize the performance of these mutually related duties" (Liddell, 1970, p. 168). This is related to accommodation in which one party concedes their position (Plowman, 1998), and it is best used in a situation where one party concedes as a signal of their degree of fairness and enlightenment.

Martinson (1994) cautioned that self-interest, entitlement, and enlightened self-interest models ignore the social dimension of ethics. He argued that persuasive communication should go beyond self-interest. The question is if ethical consideration of the public beyond professional or organizational identity is always possible and acceptable. Organizations have their own goals, values, rules, roles, or interests, which can identify them. Public relations as a part of the management function is inherently based on organizational advocacy. Even publics have their own knowledge, involvement, or interest, which is different from and often conflicting with an organization's stance around an issue. As their interest is increasing beyond involvement and knowledge, they will move away from the kingdom of ends and move toward self-interest, which will lead to asymmetrical organization--public relationships.

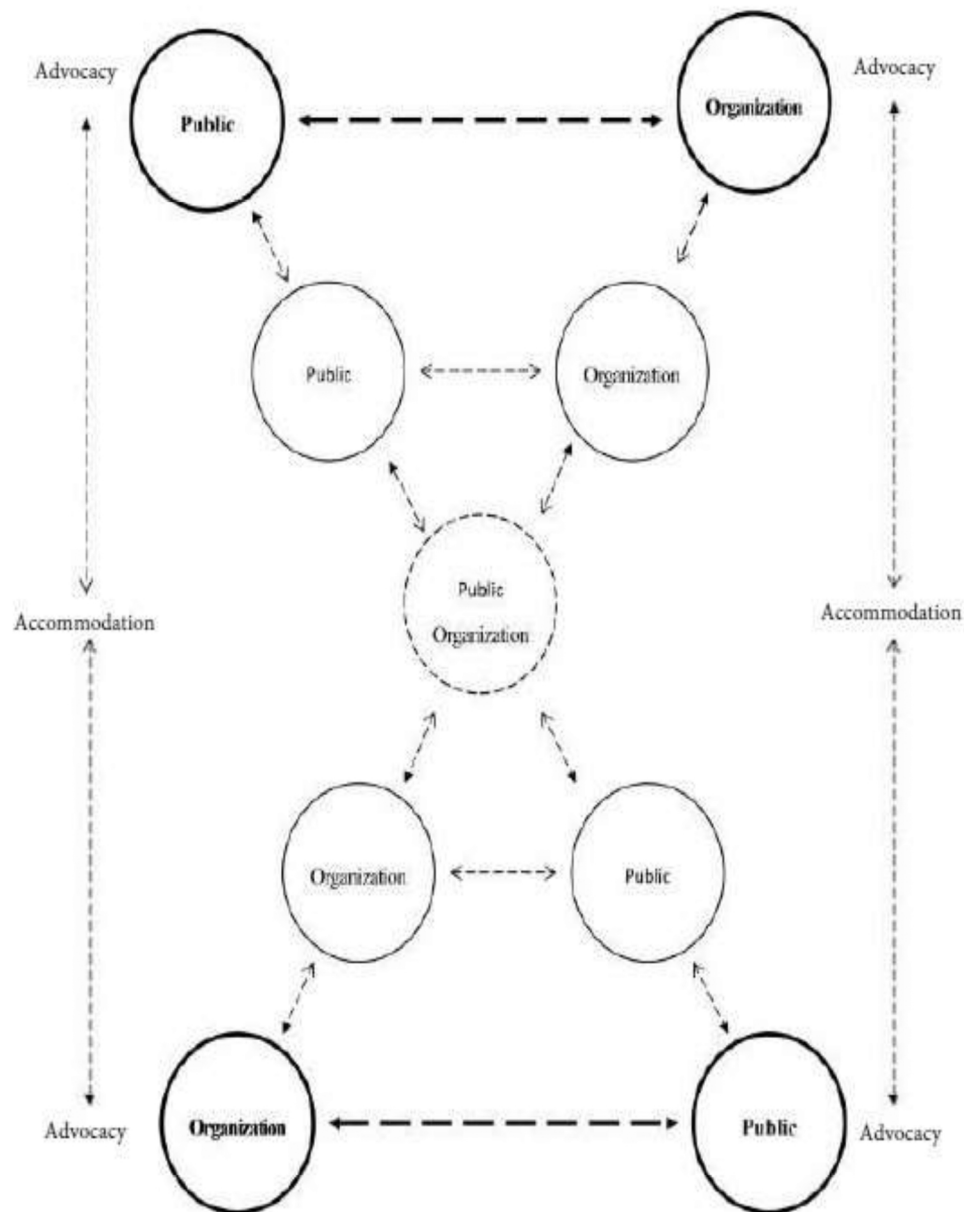


Fig. 2. Moral Dynamics on Continuum of Strategic Conflict Management.

4. Moral dynamics on continuum of strategic conflict management

4.1. Proposed model II

Fig. 1 depicts the “process” of achieving dynamic equilibrium in the organization-public relationship. Achieving dynamic equilibrium involves an endless dance of balancing and rebalancing moral stances between self-interest and communitarian ethics. Moral conflict often occurs between doing what is beneficial to the individual, fostering competitive advantage for the organization, and acting in the interest of the greater good. Likewise, Fig. 2 shows how the moral dynamics of the organization-public relationship operate on a continuum moving from one’s advocacy to accommodation through balancing and rebalancing stances to achieve a position that is advocating for self-interest and accommodating to the other in equal measure.

To conceptualize the conflicting aspect of public relations, some scholars have stressed the dynamic nature of public relations. Long and Hazelton (1987) defined public relations as “a communication function of management through which organizations adapt to, alter or maintain their environment for the purpose of achieving organizational goals” (p. 6). Others link its identity to a process and its purpose of advocacy. Cameron et al. (2008) agreed that public relations is a process in a cycle of strategic conflict management. As described in Fig. 2, the cycle of interrelationships between an organization and the public, as they take advocating or accommodating stances, is in constant flux.

Negotiation is essential in such a process. As outlined by Herman and Verbaeck (2009), the process of negotiation involves an issue, the exercise of power, which generally is divided between minority and majority groups, and settlement. The process of negotiation is about the exchange of assets versus liabilities based on the relative strengths and weaknesses of both parties. The only way that both parties will continue to engage in a negotiation is if each maintains the good faith that the other shall behave in a truthful and ethical manner. Negotiation is linked to conflict, insofar as some degree of incompatibility of goals or thwarting of the other party’s interest is at stake (Vasquez, 1996). An agreement is reached through a process of social interaction and exchange (Putnam & Roloff, 1992). Parties entering into a negotiation process select stances along the continuum of pure cooperation and pure competition (Rubin, 1983). According to Vasquez (1996), public relations professionals facilitate the process of negotiation by serving as boundary spanners capable of assessing and communicating environmental factors, organizational frames, organizational values, constituent interests, and ethical considerations.

In such a negotiation process, discussion of ethical considerations in public relations seldom extends to speculation that there is not only a socially acceptable, but also a socially necessary role for the function of persuasion or advocacy in a democratic and participatory society. Advocacy inherent in public relations is morally justified as the concept of “power” unfolded. Theorists articulated power as analogous to the behavioral ability for A to exert change in B; if A exerts force on B, a “change” will occur. They expanded definitions to recognize that power may exist whether or not force is directly used, that interest is necessary for power to be effectual, and that power is sometimes used to gain willing compliance, even when compliance is not in the interest of the powerless (Ball, 1992).

Weber (1949) claimed “power is probability that one actor within a social relationship will be in a position to carry out his own will despite resistance, regardless of the basis on which this probability rests” (p. 28), while Arendt (1993) described that power as the communal ability to communicate ideas and convictions, where agreement is the goal. Habermas (1984) placed communicative action as a goal and discussed institutionalized forms of power that inhibit its development. Power continuously brings about consequences to both an organization and the public unless the interactions cease. Public relations is an ongoing process where each entity with power is changing or changed by the other

in the process. L’Etang (2006) pointed to cultural shifts in how public relations is conceived, pulling back from “technocratic concerns,” and moving in a direction of greater socio-cultural engagement within a somewhat idealistic view of the public sphere as described by Habermas (1984, p. 39).

These claims move us toward an adequate explanation of the conflicting and changing aspect of public relations on a continuum and its nature and scope of morality in dynamic equilibrium. Moral conflicts within and among individual, organizational, and societal levels would benefit from the elaboration of autonomy and dynamic aspects of morality in public relations. Morality in public relations must be identified as it develops within and between autonomy at micro and macro levels. Autonomy entails power more than a mechanism that ties micro and macro levels together.

The issue of ethical consideration in the organization-public relationship is indeed complex at multiple levels. Public relations professionals must serve the interest of the organization, and the acceptance of public interest should ultimately align with the interest of the organization. However, an organization has its own goals, values, rules, roles, or interests, while the public has their own knowledge, involvement, or interest, which can identify themselves and may be different from or conflicting with those of the organization.

In such dynamics, power balancing can be sought only under the premise that both an organization and the public have autonomous advocacy defining their respective identity. It is self-evident that no perfectly symmetrical relationship can be forged between an organization and the public because of their difference in identity, knowledge, involvement, interest, and advocacy. The more advocacy an organization or its public has, the less concern for moral analysis that takes both sides into account exists. The proposed models (see Fig. 1 and Fig. 2) represent moral conflict and dynamic equilibrium of an organization and its public ranging from self-interest to the kingdom of ends weaving with the respective knowledge, involvement, or interest of an organization and its public. At a certain point, an organization-public relationship can be nearly symmetrical, but never stays and moves toward one or the other end in a dynamic fashion. And when an organization and the public are aligned, and almost symmetrical, it does not necessarily mean identical.

5. Conclusion

The essence of the contingency theory of strategic conflict management engaged in a dynamic process can be encapsulated by the spirit of a fine athlete breaking tackles to lunge into the end zone or a soccer player doing her best for the team. The significance of advocacy presents a challenge to the integration of ethical principles between an organization and its public, but public relations reasons that an organization needs to contribute to society through its advocacy, dialogue with stakeholders, collaborative decision-making process, alignment of interests, and cocreation of meanings (Shin & Heath, 2020), as shown in some recent social movements (Pang, Jin, Kim, & Cameron, 2020).

Moral conflicts inherent in public relations are everywhere, and public relations professionals should develop strategies to manage such conflicts in an ongoing cycle, as should other stakeholders on a moving continuum. The proposed model I represents moral conflict and dynamic equilibrium of an organization and its public ranging from self-interest to the kingdom of ends intertwining the knowledge, involvement, or interest of an organization and its public. As a way of thinking, defining public relations as strategic conflict management, the proposed model II provides an alternative to analytic debate about the benefits of symmetry, embraces autonomous individual and group processes, and holds up a non-assumptive search for social reality. Conflicting voices in such a negotiation process are essential to the collaborative development of new values and the cocreation of ideas or meanings. By defining public relations as strategic conflict management, the proposed model II shifts the debate from a focus on the ethical foundation of individual tactics

and strategies to an emphasis on the process of constructing meaning and value in society.

This theoretical paper captures the essence of public relations as strategic conflict management in a dynamic process and offers insight into the ethical premises of the contingency theory of strategic conflict management. It examines how the theory accounts for an organization and its public achieving dynamic equilibrium in a given situation by taking and then revising advocating or accommodating stances. In contrast to theories that stress mutual benefit and accommodation in dealing with moral dilemmas, contingency theory takes a realistic approach by suggesting that accommodation is not always the best and most ethical stance depending on the context. The dynamic stances and actions that facilitate stakeholder entitlement or social responsibility are always balanced against self-interest. The contingency theory of strategic conflict management seeks to capture and describe the constant dance of stances and actions aligned with consequential and deontic ethics that can guide ethical decision-making in a realistic manner.

Declaration of Competing Interest

There is no conflict of interest.

Data Availability

No data was used for the research described in the article.

References

- Alan, R. (1994). Issue communication and advocacy: Contemporary and ethical challenges. *Public Relations Review*, 20(3), 225–232.
- Alkhafaji, A. F. (1989). *Stakeholder approach to corporate governance: Managing in a dynamic environment* (pp. 203–204). Westport, CT: Greenwood Press.
- Arendt, H. (1993). *Between past and future: 20th century classics*. New York, NY: Penguin.
- Bailey, M. (1981). *Professional ethics*. Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.
- Baker, S. (1999). Five baselines for justification in persuasion. *Journal of Mass Media Ethics*, 14(2), 69–81.
- Ball, T. (1992). New faces of power. In T. E. Wartenberg (Ed.), *Rethinking power*. Albany, NY: State University of New York Press.
- Barney, R. D., & Black, J. (1994). Ethics and professional persuasive communications. *Public Relations Review*, 20(3), 233–249.
- Baskin, O., & Arnoff, C. (1992). *Public relations: The profession and the practice*. Dubuque, IA: Brown.
- Bivins, T. H. (1987). Applying ethical theory to public relations. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 6, 195–200.
- Black, J. (1992). Media ethics. In M. Murray, & A. Ferri (Eds.), *Teaching mass communication: A guide to better instruction* (pp. 235–253). New York, NY: Praeger.
- Blumer, H. (1966). The mass, the public and public opinion. In B. Erelson (Ed.), *Reader in public opinion and communication* (pp. 45–50). New York, NY: New Free Press.
- Bradley, F. H. (1962). *Ethical studies*. London, UK: Oxford University Press.
- Broom, G. M., & Dozier, D. M. (1994). *Effective public relations* (seventh ed.). Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice Hall.
- Buchanan, J. M. (1965). Ethical rules, expected values and large numbers. *Ethics*, 76, 1–13.
- Cameron, G. T. (1997). The contingency theory of conflict management in public relations. *Proceedings of the Norwegian Information Service*. Oslo, Norway.
- Cameron, G. T., Cropp, F., & Reber, B. H. (2001). Getting past platitudes: Factors limiting accommodation in public relations. *Journal of Communication Management*, 5(3), 242–261.
- Cameron, G. T., Wilcox, D. L., Reber, B. H., & Shin, J. H. (2008). *Public relations today: Managing competition and conflict*. Boston, MA: Pearson Education, Inc.
- Cancel, A. E., Cameron, G. T., Sallot, L. M., & Mitrook, M. A. (1997). It depends: A contingency theory of accommodation in public relations. *Journal of Public Relations Research*, 9(1), 31–63.
- Christians, C., Fackler, M., & Rotzoll, K. (1995). *Media ethics: Cases and moral reasoning* (p. 330). New York, NY: Longman.
- Dewey, J. U. (1927). *The public and its problems*. Athens, OH: Swallow Press.
- Edgett, R. (2002). Toward an ethical framework for advocacy in public relations. *Journal of Public Relations Research*, 14(1), 1.
- Fagothey, A. (1976). *Right and reason: Ethics in theory and practice*. St. Louis, MO: Mosby.
- Ferguson, M. A. (1984). *Building theory in public relations: Interorganizational relationships*. Paper presented at the annual meeting of the Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication, Gainesville, FL.
- Finnell, T., & Fleming, J. (1997). Raising the bar on market conduct. *National Underwriter Life and Health-financial Services*. (<http://library.iacet.com/html/searchbank.html>).
- Fisher, R., & Ury, W. (1986). *Getting to YES*. Melbourne, Australia: Hutchinson Business.
- Fisher, R. J. (1997). *Interactive conflict resolution*. Syracuse, NY: Syracuse University Press.
- Flynn, T. (2006). A delicate equilibrium: Balancing theory, practice, and outcomes. *Journal of Public Relations Research*, 18(2), 191–201.
- Grunig, J. E., Grunig, L. A., & Dozier, D. M. (2006). Excellence theory. In C. Botan, & V. Hazelton (Eds.), *Public relations theory II* (pp. 19–54). New York, NY: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates.
- Guy, M. E. (1990). *Ethical decision making in everyday work situations*. New York, NY: Quorum Books.
- Habermas, J. (1984). *The theory of communicative action, Vol. 1: Reason and the rationalization of society* (T. McCarthy Trans.). Boston, MA: Beacon Press.
- Hallahan, K. (2000). Enhancing motivation, ability, and opportunity to process public relations messages. *Public Relations Review*, 26(4), 463.
- Heiner, R. (1985). The origin of predictable behavior. *American Economic Review*, 73(4), 560–595.
- Hellweg, S. A. (1989). *The application of Grunig's symmetry-asymmetry public relations models to internal communications systems*. Paper presented at the meeting of the International Communication Association. San Francisco, CA.
- Herman, L., & Verbaeck, B. (2009). Narrative interests as cultural negotiation. *Narrative*, 17(1), 111–129.
- Hocker, J. L., & Wilmot, W. W. (1991). *Interpersonal conflict*. Dubuque, IA: Wm. C. Brown Publishers.
- Jaksa, J., & Pritchard, M. (1994). *Communication ethics: Methods of analysis*. Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.
- Kant, I. (1964). In *Groundwork of the metaphysics of morals*. (H. J. Paton, Trans.). New York, NY: Harper & Row Publishers.
- Kant, I. (1965). The metaphysical elements of justice. In J. Ladd (Ed.), *The metaphysics of morals*. Indianapolis, IN: Bobbs-Merrill.
- L'Etang, J. (2006). Public relations and propaganda: Conceptual issues, methodological problems, and public relations discourse. In J. L'Etang, & M. Piecska (Eds.), *Public relations: Critical debates and contemporary practice* (pp. 23–40). Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates.
- Ledingham, J. A., & Bruning, S. D. (2000). *Public relations as relationship management: A relational approach to the study and practice of public relations*. Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates.
- Leichty, G. (1997). The limits of collaboration. *Public Relations Review*, 23(1), 47–55.
- Liddell, B. E. A. (1970). *Kant on the foundation of morality: A modern version of the Grundlegung*. Bloomington, IN: Indiana University Press.
- Long, W. W., & Hazelton, V. (1987). Public relations: A theoretical and practical response. *Public Relations Review*, 13(2), 3–14.
- Martinson, D. L. (1994). Enlightened self-interest fails as an ethical baseline in public relations. *Journal for Mass Media Ethics*, 9(2), 100–108.
- Martinson, D. L. (1995). Ethical public relations practitioners must not ignore public interest. *Journal of Mass Media Ethics*, 10(4), 210–222.
- Mata, A. (2019). Social metacognition in moral judgment: Decisional conflict promotes perspective taking. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology: Attitudes and Social Cognition*, 117(3), 1061–1082.
- McBride, G. (1989). Ethical thought in public relations history: Seeking a relevant perspective. *Journal of Mass Media Ethics*, 4(1), 5–20.
- Mises, L. V. (2005). *Liberalism: The classical tradition*. Indianapolis, IN: Liberty Fund, Inc.
- Moffitt, M. A. (1992). Bringing critical theory and ethical considerations to definitions of a "public. *Public Relations Review*, 18(1), 17–29.
- Murphy, P. (1991). The limits of symmetry: A game theory approach to symmetric and asymmetrical public relations. In L. A. Grunig, & J. E. Grunig (Eds.), *Public Relations Research Annual* (Vol. 3, pp. 115–131). Hillsdale, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum.
- Nelson, R. (1994). Issues communication and advocacy: Contemporary ethical challenges. *Public Relations Review*, 20, 225–231.
- Nelson, W. A. (2008). The organizational costs of ethical conflicts. *Journal of Healthcare Management*, 53(1), 41–53.
- Newsom, D., Turk, J., & Kruckeberg, D. (1996). *This is PR*. Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.
- Nomos, V. (1967). Prolegomena to a theory of the public interest. In Carl J. Friedrich (Ed.), *The public interest*. New York, NY: Atherton Press.
- Olasky, M. N. (1984). Retrospective: Bernays' doctrine of public opinion. *Public Relations Review*, 10(4), 3–11.
- Pang, A., Jin, Y., Kim, S., & Cameron, G. T. (2020). Contingency theory: Evolution from a public relations theory to a theory of strategic conflict management. In *Crisis Communication* (pp. 141–164). Berlin, Germany: De Gruyter Mouton.
- Pearce, W. B., & Littlejohn, S. W. (1997). *Moral conflict: When social worlds collide*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications Ltd.
- Plowman, K. D. (1998). Power of conflict in public relations. *Journal of Public Relations Research*, 10(4), 237–261.
- Plowman, K. D., ReVelle, C., Meirovich, S., Pien, M., Stemple, R., Sheng, V., & Fay, K. (1995). Walgreens: A case study in health care issues and conflict resolution. *Journal of Public Relations Research*, 7, 231–258.
- Pratt, C. (1991). Public relations: The empirical research on practitioner ethics. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 10(3), 229–237.
- Pratt, C. (1993). Critique of the classical theory of situational ethics in U.S. public relations. *Public Relations Review*, 19(3), 219–245.
- Pratt, C. (1994). Research progress in public relations ethics: An overview. *Public Relations Review*, 20(3), 217–224.
- Putnam, L. L., & Roloff, M. E. (1992). Communication perspectives on negotiation. In L. Putnam, & M. Roloff (Eds.), *Communication and negotiation* (pp. 1–20). Newbury Park, CA: Sage.
- Rand, A. (1982). *Philosophy: Who needs it?* Indianapolis, IN: Bobbs-Merrill.
- Rawls, J. (1971). *A theory of justice*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Ross, W. (1930). *The right and the good*. Oxford, UK: Clarendon.
- Rubin, J. Z. (1983). Negotiation: An introduction to some issues and themes. *American Behavioral Scientist*, 27, 135–147.

- Rubin, J. Z., Pruitt, D. G., & Kim, S. H. (1994). *Social conflict: Escalation, stalemate, and settlement*. New York, NY: McGraw-Hill, Inc.
- Sallot, L. (1993). *The effects of motive, communication style, and licensing on the reputation of public relations: An impression management perspective* (Unpublished doctoral dissertation). Gainesville: University of Florida.
- Seitel, F. (1995). *The practice of public relations* (sixth ed.). Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice Hall.
- Shin, J.H. (2003). *Strategic conflict management of the source-reporter relationship between public relations practitioners and journalists* (Unpublished doctoral dissertation). Columbia, MO: University of Missouri-Columbia.
- Shin, J. H., & Heath, R. L. (2020). *Public relations theory: Capabilities and competences*. Boston, MA: Wiley-Blackwell.
- Singer, N., Kruzpointner, L., Sommer, M., Wüst, S., & Kudielka, M. (2019). Decisionmaking in everyday moral conflict situations: Development and validation of a new measure. *PLoS One*, 14(4), 1–19.
- Smith, N. (1995). Marketing strategies for the ethics era. *Sloan Management Review*, 36(4), 85–97.
- Stauber, J., & Rampton, S. (1995). *Toxic sludge is good for you*. Monroe, ME: Common Courage.
- Sullivan, R. J. (1989). *Immanuel Kant's moral theory*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press.
- Tapscott, D., & Ticoll, D. (2003). From personal influence to interpersonal influence: A model for relationship management. In J. A. Ledingham, & S. D. Bruning (Eds.), *Public relations as relationship management: A relational approach to the study and practice of public relations* (pp. 221–238). Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates, Inc.
- Tatalovich, R. (2017). The life cycle of moral conflicts: Why some die, but others persist. *The Journal of Policy History*, 29(4), 676–701.
- Tillet, G. (1990). A working definition of conflict. In J. Bottes (Ed.), *Basic readings in conflict analysis and resolution*. Fairfax VA: Institute for Conflict Analysis and Resolution, George Mason University.
- Toth, E. L., & Trujillo, N. (1987). Reinventing corporate communications. *Public Relations Review*, 13, 42–53.
- Vasquez, G. (1994). Testing a communication theory-method-message-behavior complex for the investigation for publics. *Journal of Public Relations Research*, 6, 267–297.
- Vasquez, G. M. (1996). Public relations as negotiation: An issue development perspective. *Journal of Public Relations Research*, 8(1), 57–77.
- Vergobbi, D. (1995). Ethical public relations practitioners must not ignore public interest. *Journal of Mass Media Ethics*, 10(4), 233–245.
- Weber, M. (1949). *The methodology of the social sciences*. New York, NY: Free Press.
- Wilcox, D. L., Cameron, G. T., Reber, B. H., & Shin, J. H. (2013). *Think Public relations* (second ed.). Upper Saddle River, NJ: Pearson.
- Wilcox, D. L., Reber, B. H., Shin, J. H., & Cameron, G. T. (2023). *Public relations strategies and tactics* (12th ed.). Upper Saddle River, NJ: Pearson Education, Inc.
- Wright, D. K. (1993). Enforcement dilemma: Voluntary nature of public relations codes. *Public Relations Review*, 19(1), 13–21.